

TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

THE NDA GOVERNMENT DOES NOT HAVE THE NUMBERS TO PUSH THE AMENDMENTS THROUGH. THREE SENIOR MINISTERS ARE ENGAGING WITH OPPOSITION MEMBERS TO SEEK COMMON GROUND ON ONOP

first amendment bill concerns election laws related to the Lok Sabha and state assemblies, which fall under the purview of Parliament, it will not require ratification from the states. However, the second one, dealing with local body elections—a subject under state jurisdiction—will need approval from at least half of the state legislatures. Amendments to Article 325, which governs the electoral rolls, would also need ratification by at least half the states.

In the 543-member Lok Sabha, the NDA would require 364 votes to secure a two-third majority, a number far beyond its current 293 seats in the 18th Lok Sabha. Likewise, in the Rajya Sabha, where the threshold is 164 votes, the NDA's 121 seats fall well short. To pass the proposed amendments, the ruling coalition would need the backing of non-NDA parties, making external support crucial.

The Kovind committee, which sought inputs from 62 political parties, found that 32—largely from the NDA—were in favour of the proposals, while 15 opposed it, denouncing it as undemocratic and contrary to the principles of federalism. These 15 parties, which include 203 MPs from the Opposition INDIA bloc, collectively represent 205 seats in the Lok Sabha. The 15 parties that did not provide feedback further complicate the political calculus. According to sources, the cabinet has assigned three senior ministers—defence minister Rajnath Singh, law minister Arjun Ram Meghwal and parliamentary affairs minister Kiren Rijiju—to engage with Opposition parties and seek common ground on the proposal.

WHY BACK ONOP?

The central argument in favour hinges on the promise of cost savings and uninterrupted governance. Advocates, particularly within the BJP, assert that the constant cycle of elections drains the public coffers, disrupts governance through the repeated enforcement of the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) and diverts administrative resources away from development work.

A NITI Aayog report says the past three decades have not seen a single year without an election, either to the Lok Sabha, state assemblies or both. This perennial electoral cycle, ONOP supporters argue, fosters short-term populism, encouraging unsustainable welfare measures that come at the expense of long-term infrastructure growth and efficient public service delivery. A unified electoral schedule would also reduce campaign expenses of po-